designated the blinder.[64]

Eventually, Jouher said he would ride after Humayun and ask him; Ali Dost followed closely behind. Humayun wasn't happy to see them, nor to hear from Ali Dost that 'No one will perform the business'. Humayun swore at him and snapped, 'Why don't you do it yourself?'

Ali Dost returned to Kamran with his orders; Kamran declared he would rather be killed. It isn't hard to understand why: what would it be for a man of his ambition and energy to live the life of an enfeebled prisoner, groping in the dark? A fate far worse than death.

'We dare not exceed our orders,' said Ghulam Ali, with bleak, pedantic finality. Then, as if in a sudden hurry to get the unpleasant task over and done with, Ghulam Ali and Ali Dost stuffed a handkerchief into Kamran's mouth, dragged him out of his tent, laid him down and pierced his eyes with a small, sharp knife. 'This they repeated at least fifty times,' writes Jouher, but Kamran made not the slightest moan – until, in the end, they squeezed lemon juice into his ravaged eyes and he cried out, 'O Lord, O Lord, my God . . .'

Some days later, Kamran appeared before Humayun, to seek his permission to go on the pilgrimage to Mecca, a common form of exile or retirement. Humayun agreed, and asked if any of the prince's retainers would accompany him. 'No one came forward,' writes Abul Fazl. Humayun had to send his own table attendant with his brother.

Thus, alone and unmourned, Kamran left his home, his kingdom, his family behind, sailing down the Indus to Sindh and then to Mecca where, five years later, he died.

In history, too, Kamran has been a lonely, unmourned figure, the faithless brother and evil prince. There are only the rarest glimpses of the younger brother's tragedy, and the older brother's guilt. Jouher's 'very melancholy mood' after the blinding, for example, suggests that Kamran was not the unpopular villain he's made out to be[65] – 'more sinned against than sinning', as a modern historian puts it.[66] A year later, in the winter of 1553, when Humayun returned to Kabul, he didn't want to celebrate the end of his long feud, let alone talk about it. When the women of the harem came to greet him, he told them not to congratulate him on Kamran's defeat, for 'it was as if he had struck at his own eyes'.[67] In fact, by this time, all three of